LOYALISTS

> "GREEN IS ... THE BEST COLOUR FOR LIGHT TROOPS ... AND IF PUT ON IN THE SPRING, BY AUTUMN IT NEARLY FADES WITH THE LEAVES."
>
> **JOHN GRAVES SIMCOE,** COMMANDER OF THE QUEEN'S RANGERS 1777–83

Considerable numbers of Americans fought on the British side in the war. Some participated in provincial regiments of the British army – for example, the King's Royal Regiment created by Loyalist refugees in Canada in 1776, and the Caledonian Volunteers composed of Loyalist Scottish settlers. Some of these units, like the New York-based Queen's Rangers, proved to be tough fighting men capable of welding American rifle marksmanship and flexible tactics to British discipline. Others fought as militia or irregulars, often under British officers, waging partisan warfare against the rebels. Butler's Rangers, a mixed force of Loyalists and Indians, was responsible for a notorious massacre in Wyoming Valley in 1778. Tarleton's Raiders, operating in the Carolinas, also earned a fearsome reputation. Black slaves fought for the British in return for a promise of freedom, both as regulars in Lord Dunmore's Ethiopian Regiment, raised in 1775, and as guerrillas. At the war's end most Loyalist fighters, black or white, chose to leave the United States.



Queen's Rangers uniform
Founded in 1776 in New York, the Queen's Rangers was the first regiment in the British army to wear green uniforms for the purposes of camouflage.

HESSIANS

About a third of British forces engaged in the war were German mercenaries hired for the duration of the conflict. These "Hessians" came not only from Hessen-Kassel and Hessen-Hannau, but also from a number of other petty German princedoms that provided contingents of troops in return for a cash payment. Such mercenary service, contracted at government level, was standard practice in 18th-century European armies.

The Hessians were not notably inferior to British soldiers in battlefield performance or in their behaviour towards civilians. Most were schooled in the standard musket-and-bayonet style of combat, but companies of *jäger* – light rifle-armed troops – made excellent skirmishers. Clad in green for camouflage, these German hunters on occasion outperformed the American rifleman as snipers and woodland fighters.

The American Congress and states attempted to bribe the Hessians with offers of land and livestock. Many did desert, but no more than was normal for a European army on campaign. Around 60 per cent of the 30,000 Hessians eventually returned home. Combat losses were quite low, but many died of disease. The rest presumably made new lives for themselves in America.